On ECHOES of INVISIBLE HEARTS

Image Making and Popular Archiving in Times of Unrest

On

ECHOES of INVISIBLE HEARTS

Image Making and Popular Archiving in Times of Unrest

April 17 – May 5, 2019
STATION Beirut, Lebanon

CURATED BY LILA NAZEMIAN

Alia Ali

Yasmine Diaz

Thana Faroq

Arif Al Nomay

Rahman Taha

Ibn Seera

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DIWAN AL–FAN

Diwan Al Fan is dedicated to supporting visual art from Yemen through local and international projects – including exhibitions, art residencies, workshops and productions. Providing a global perspective on Yemeni art and culture, Diwan Al Fan encourages the development of projects that expand the discourse around contemporary art, music and film from Yemen.

Diwan Al Fan is the arts program of the newly established Sana'a based Romooz Foundation for the Arts and Cultural Development.

ROMOOZ FOUNDATION

Located in the city of Sana'a, Yemen, Romooz Foundation is an independent, non–profit foundation dedicated to the promotion and development of Yemeni Art and Culture. Through local and international exhibitions featuring the work of Yemeni artists, music production, trainings, residencies, workshops, literature events, conferences, film festivals, artists talks, and public programming, the Foundation aims to contribute to the development of a pluralistic, democratic society in Yemen. The organization aims to promote art as a means for conflict resolution, peace–building, learning and social development. Through partnership with international foundations and non–profit organizations, Romooz aims to encourage the Yemeni public to interact with Arts, and Artists and understand that there is no human development without art and culture.

www.romoozfoundation.org

FRIEDRICH–EBERT–STIFTUNG

The Friedrich–Ebert–Stiftung (FES) is the oldest political foundation in Germany. Its rich tradition in social democracy dates back to its foundation in 1925 and owes its mission to the political endowment of its namesake: Friedrich Ebert, the first democratically–elected German President.

Today, it remains loyal to Ebert's legacy and campaigns the core ideas and values of social democracy: freedom, justice and solidarity. In its work worldwide, FES maintains a close connection to social democracy and free trade unions.

FES promotes the advancement of social democracy through:

- Political and educational work to strengthen civil society and the support of young talent
- Development of strategies on the core issues of just and sustainable economic, social and educational policies, fostering a public discourse on these issues
- International cooperation facilitated by a network of offices in more than 100 countries
- Maintaining the collective memory of social democracy with archives, libraries and more

FES IN YEMEN

In 1997 FES began to conduct activities in Yemen. The FES Yemen office was established only two years later, in the old city of Sana'a.

Today, the main working areas of FES Yemen include promoting gender and youth participation for an increased social and political participation, as well as democratisation processes. The project further aims at fostering socio–economic challenges by offering a platform for the development of new approaches to socially–just economic policies. Through trainings in the field of peacebuilding and conflict transformation, FES Yemen supports civil–society initiatives in dealing with conflicts on a local level and maintaining social cohesion.

www.fesyemen.org

IMAGE MAKING AND POPULAR ARCHIVING IN TIMES OF UNREST

Official histories form central parts of national narratives which are in turn upheld by various cultural, educational and bureaucratic institutions. History is not stagnant but rather gradually evolves as national contexts shift. When wars or other seminal events occur, their chronicling is continuously in development through diverse means of documentation. Historical narratives are rendered seamless by a series of events made interrelated through the deductions and priorities of tasked writers, which are later transmitted to a population. Omissions and errassures of the past also often form part of this codification, and can contribute to a popular amnesia of events occured.

The tools of documenting in modern times have often involved the use of photography. Yet photojournalists and documentary filmmakers in the West are far from objective observers. Early War photographers were often used by Western governments as conduits of positive propaganda images from the forefronts of combat and, it was later discovered that many of these images were in fact staged (Matthew Brady, Alexander Gardner, Roger Fenton, Felice Beato, and continued speculations about Robert Capa, among others). It was not until the Vietnam War that photojournalists became vocal critics and as such, have since been thoroughly censored by those engaged in conflicts. Reporters and media outlets are no longer guaranteed access to conflict zones and even those that are permitted to observe, do so under the blessing of the armed forces, rarely resulting in critical stories about their gracious hosts.

What does it mean then, for an individual to be a witness of war? Everything and nothing. It could encompass momentous triumphs and defeats on a national scale, as well as life and all its banalities during tumultuous times. No history is free of subjectivity, and neither is collective memory. With regards to the war in Yemen, which has now entered its fourth year, too many stories in the media are full of contextual omissions or absent altogether. How are artists, as part of the populace, documenting this war? Are they able to provide an alternative record that is sorely needed in such dark times?

On Echoes of Invisible Hearts: Image Making and Popular Archiving in Times of Unrest brings together six Yemeni artists whose works explore the ways in which the current instability haunting their homeland is being processed, recorded and remembered. By questioning the power of images in shaping memory, they reimagine dominant national narratives. They furthermore challenge the ways in which conflicts are recorded by societies and present alternative paradigms of

representation. The second edition of this location–specific series takes place in Beirut, Lebanon, where the population has undergone decades of processing and rewriting of their own history of civil strife.

Yasmine Diaz's mixed–media collage works examine the discrepancies within the American media's coverage of the current crisis in Yemen. Salon.com reported that MSNBC failed to once mention the war in Yemen during the same period that they aired 455 segments on a mistress of President Donald Trump. Inspired by this article for *Averting is Easy*, Diaz sourced print content from major U.S. news outlets such as The New York Times, The Wall Street Journal, USA Today and the Los Angeles Times, to produced a layered collages at the backdrop of burning flames. Another piece, *August 10, 2018*, marks the day a Saudi–led coalition airstrike hit a bus in Northern Yemen, resulting in the deaths of over 50 civilians, including numerous children. Mimicking the front page of a newspaper, the collage is devoid of any color or text, and obscures the sole image, simply emphasizing the date at the top of the page. This story did ultimately make headlines as it was revealed that the bombs used in the attack were made by U.S. weapons manufacturers. In her latest work, *Fool's Gold*, Diaz creates an abstract graph that correlates the sudden rise in coverage about Yemen with the murder of Jamal Khashoggi, revealing that as the media slowly moved on from reports of the murder, so did their attention towards the war in Yemen. The piece focuses on the moral cost of America's economic interests for which Saudi Arabia continues to be supported. These incidents have, however, been pivotal in the various resolutions put forth by the American Senate and Congress, whom have halted the U.S. military's involvement in this conflict to the detriment of its Saudi allies. Diaz's works point to the power of the media in bringing conversations about government involvement to the forefront of political debates. The media can be an ally in informing the the populace, or can perpetuate ignorance by failing to perform its journalistic duties.

Alia Ali's multi–media and sound installation, *Jenaza*, also focuses on the school bus bombing that killed innocent civilians. Ali's voice can be heard naming the victims of the attack, while 42 folded sets of white cloth placed on the floor commemorate those killed and address their posthumous martyrization. Burial traditions in the Islamic faith require that the deceased body be washed and shrouded in white cloth before being placed in the grave. Martyrs however, are believed to die pure and do not need to be cleaned or wrapped. Here the artist emphasizes the significance of martyrdom in Shi'ism, in addition to revealing the politicization of this tragedy. Ultimately, she suggests that these individuals, adults and children alike, were murdered, not martyred. Accompanying this installation is the three–channel video *War, News and Law*, which addresses the capitalist incentives feeding continuous unrest in the region, the media's manipulation of information, and the U.S. legal institutions that uphold its imperialist agenda.

Textile is a central element in much of Ali's practice. Her *BORDERLAND* series highlights

traditions and tensions from border regions across the world. In her *Yemeni Series*, the artist, fully wrapped in a colorful traditional cloth, is juxtaposed against the backdrop of another vibrant fabric. In other portraits from the series, the traditional garbs that she poses with are placed against a black background. By occulting herself within the folds and layers of the textile, Ali emphasizes the binaries present in all individuals: belonging versus exile, individual identity versus shared heritage, freedom versus oppression, and illusion versus reality. The use and production of textiles can be traced back to the earliest development of human civilizations, and serves not only to cover bodies or to decorate surfaces, but also to communicate and record history. Yemen is one of the oldest civilizations on earth and within the fibers and pattern of these traditional textiles are the memories of past and present.

In *Ali*, Rahman Taha presents a multi–media installation exploring history and memory in Yemen through a day in the life of Ali—an elderly man who has spent the majority of his life working in Yemen's renowned coffee plantations in the Haraz mountains of the Northwest. Nearly 80 years old, Ali has lived through Yemen's major conflicts over the past century. Through photographs, filmed discussions, and shadowing of the subject throughout his daily activities, viewers are privy to a substitute history of Yemen: one which evades the nation's linear events.. Instead, Ali's perspectives are facetious, mundane and at times, incomprehensible. They touch upon larger concepts of life, the shifting nature of relations between men and women in Yemen that Ali has observed over past decades, in addition to reflections on politics and history.

Another central figure in this work is the landscape of the mountain–range itself, and Ali's relationship to the land, which pertains to his profession as a coffee grower. Through inquiries about his work, Ali reveals detailed knowledge about the earth that he has cultivated his whole life, and other technicalities of this industry throughout Yemen's recent history. The landscape, its colors, aroma, and the omnipresence of its harvest in sustaining life in that region, is a larger testament to history. It is a reminder that the geology of this land has existed and will continue to exist far longer than any human or man–made conflict.

In the video *(de)Constructing Heritage*, Ibn Seera uses primary and secondary photographic research to record architectural shifts that have taken place in the Yemeni city of Aden following various eras of unrest. Yemen is renowned for its striking architecture that was developed over centuries by builders and craftsmen using locally sourced materials suiting the specific climate and geography of the region. Both the North and South boast unique architectural design traits that highlight the diversity throughout the country. As Yemen suffered consecutive civil strifes, cities all over the country have also borne the wreckage of this destruction.

However, for a variety of reasons, efforts to rebuild have often fallen short of maintaining the identity of regional architectural traditions, which has led to a further loss of cultural heritage.

Ibn Seera's video consists of the artist revealing to the viewer a map of Aden and opening image files from folders on a computer desktop pertaining to specific buildings and other iconic structures throughout the city. Specifically, the study looks at schools, historical landmarks, shuttered windows and places of worship, such as mosques of varying sects and synagogues. As the viewer observes juxtaposed images of the same structures following their destruction/reconstruction throughout various historical eras, the physical change in the architecture and facades and outright erasure of the buildings is evident. The artist, who uses a nom de plume, adamantly preserves this visual history in the face of political danger and retaliation.

Arif Al Nomay's *Corrupted Files* series is heavily symbolic in its poetic undertones on Yemen's recent past vis–a–vis its current state. The artist documented the 2014 Sana'a Summer Festival, which each year, celebrated Yemeni heritage and traditions through a series of events, performances, retail stands, children's amusement activities, and government sponsored group marriages for those unable to afford the associated costs. Al Nomay happened to have documented the last of such festivals which have no longer taken place since the start of Yemen's most recent war. Consisting of a happenstance technical glitch, hundreds of photos taken at the festival appear corrupted when opened on Al Nomay's computer. The photos were taken after the Yemeni government had undergone two years of transitional negotiations at the National Dialogue Conference, which had followed the political unrest spawned by the Yemeni Arab Spring Uprising. The corrupted images have become compilations of multiple photographs, with some sections and colors left intact, while others are pixelated and indistinguishable. Yet individuals, objects, and landscapes are visible despite the visual chaos of this joyous and lighthearted celebration. Some photographs from that day were not damaged and will be presented for the first time alongside the corrupted images in a large–scale grid, displaying the disjointed elements in various works and showcasing the magnitude of the series as a whole.

Similarly dealing with the erasure of images, Thana Faroq's series, *In Search of Lost Photographs*, was born out of the partial loss of the artist's photo archives. The photographs had originally been taken between 2013–2014 during the National Dialogue Conference following Yemen's Uprising in 2011.. Amidst the shock and devastation of losing over 1000 photos taken in her hometown, Sana'a, she embarked on a project to recreate images that she no longer possessed.

Faroq is unable to return to Sana'a, and even were she able to travel there, she could not recreate scenes prior to the current war; many of the individuals that she had captured on camera have fled the city or are no longer alive. The 18 images that constitute this series possess attributes that simulate the appearance of digitally scanned archival photographs. This is, however, a fabrication by

the artist, who has not found her lost photographs, but has instead, (re)created them.

The new images are taken from the artist's surviving archives of digital photographs. Upon encountering an image that reminds her of another that was lost, she transforms it into a photograph from her memory by removing the color and digitally enhancing the graininess, among other alterations. In the process of creating certain works, she began to recall the visuals of other photographs which, in turn, led to all the works in this series. The making of *In Search of Lost Photographs*, is an exercise of remembering what ultimately blurs fact and fiction, reality and recollection. It is an echoing archive of Faroq's fragmented memories.

Images have been used throughout history for their unquestionable power in creating and swaying narratives. The artists in *On Echoes of Invisible Hearts: Image Making and Popular Archiving in Times of Unrest* similarly use images and video to present the artists' own varying narratives on Yemen and its heritage. The works mediate the latest war, its larger traumas and their experienced displacement through the use of alternative tools of documentation. As witnesses, the artists add layers of critical nuance without aligning themselves to any specific political agenda. By approaching the topics at hand through diverse methods, they each present different themes in context with one another. The artists are all individuals with independent memories and experiences of Yemen that extend beyond the current conflict. The works reflect and preserve history through storytelling by addressing the personal, the national,and even, the universal.

Reflecting on the humanity of individuals in times of war in her book, "Regarding the Pain of Others," Susan Sontag explains, "(...) the scale of war's murderousness destroys what identifies people as individuals, even as human beings."[1] Indeed, the toll of human, personal and shared loss experienced during wars is ubiquitous and is even reflected in the development of collective amnesias. In many ways, the artists blur the personal and collective so as to emphasize the humanity of those suffering from the instability ravaging across Yemen. The works further address the subjectivity in documenting history, and complicate the agency and authority of those who record. The liminality in scope of these works reflect the possibilities of an imagined future and a revised past. They represent some of the ways in which stories of this conflict will be transmitted to future generations of Yemenis and be instilled in their collective memory. *On Echoes of Invisible Hearts* challenges viewers to question their understanding of stagnant institutional histories, and to reflect upon instances of erasure and memory loss.

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By Lila Nazemian
March 2019

[1] Sontag, Susan. Regarding the Pain of Others. Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 2017.

ALIA ALI

One of the most renowned stories of the Prophet Mohammed pertains to his escape from enemies trying to capture him. An angel tells him to find shelter in a cave, and despite his concern, insists until he abides. He acknowledges the presence of a spider at the entrance of the cave before entering. Upon entering, the spider weaves an intricate web across the cave's entry. While his enemies catch up to him, they conclude that it would have been impossible for him to be inside the cave without having broken the web, resulting in the survival of the Prophet. As he eventually moves onward to Mecca, he must break the very web that concealed him. Muslims are never to kill a spider as they are considered to be "بركة," a blessing.

Thread, like photography, can be used as both a tool and a weapon. In the series of auto–portraits, *UNDER THREAD*, Ali combines the two in an installation addressing paradoxical notions surrounding conflict and peace, active participation and passive absenteeism, hopefulness and despair, complicity and ignorance, government involvement and individual participation. This series of photographs is an interrogative body of work, that the artist approach as a citizen of her native land, Yemen, and of her adopted land, the United States.

Jenaza consists a sound installation and 42 pieces of cloth, folded five times and placed in a grid. The work provides a metonym for the child victims of the Dhayhan school bus attack in Sa'ada Province, Yemen, on August 10th, 2018, by a US supplied bomb made by Lockheed Martin. The artist's voice can be heard naming the victims and presenting the culprits embroiled through an accompanying the three channel video, War, News and Law. The videos explore the capitalist nature of war embroiled with weapons manufacturers, the role of the media in manipulating information, and institutions of law that perpetuate the cyclical tendencies of global imperialism.

Following page
Jenaza, 2019
42 – 7 ft. muslin cloths folded five times
in squares of 11 in x 11in / 28 x 28 cm
11 ft x 11ft / 335.28 x 335.28 cm
Sound installation, 3 minutes and 52 seconds
(Installation shot at California Institute of Fine Arts)

Following spread
UNDER THREAD Series, 2019
Pigment Print on photorag mounted on
Aluminum Dibond with UV Laminate
21.2 x 14.1 in / 54 x 36 cm (Each)

Textile is significant as it is something that we are born into it, we sleep in it, we eat on it, we define ourselves by it, we shield ourselves with it and, eventually, we die in it. While it unites us, it simultaneously divides us, both physically and symbolically. Artist Alia Ali uses textiles to represent the fabricated barriers in society that often segregate and connect us through fear, discrimination, and misunderstanding.

In the continuation of her series *BORDERLAND*, artist Alia Ali presents the Yemeni Series. *BORDERLAND* was inspired by the aggressive push to block access, coupled with a strong nationalistic phenomenon taking precedence over providing security and refuge for those in greatest need. This discourse has already begun to build walls around the globe while simultaneously eroding communities built on diversity. In her Yemen Series, the artist reclaims her heritage by shifting the Western gaze to that of the East, looking at Yemen through its beauty rather its suffering. It's only through this lens that we can know what is at stake during the systematic erasure of Yemeni communities and heritage which is being permanently scarred by imprints of power and destruction. Who is on the other side of the fabric questions the very nature of belonging and interrogates the binary of home and exile. In the human act of processing our surroundings, we unconsciously categorize. We separate good from evil; familiar from unfamiliar; threat from safety; alien from native... We, influenced by categorizations create these dichotomies ourselves. The theme of duality extends to questioning the moment in which the mysterious becomes apparent, freedom becomes restraint, and illusion becomes reality.

Spread pages 26– 27
Yemenia (*BORDERLAND* Series), 2019
Pigment print on cotton rag
65 x 23.6 in / 165 x 60 cm

BORDERLAND: Yemeni Series, 2019
Pigment print on cotton rag
42 x 28 in / 107 x 72 cm

Spread pages 28 –29
BORDERLAND: Yemeni Series, 2019
Pigment print on cotton rag
42 x 28 in / 107 x 72 cm

BORDERLAND: Yemeni Series, 2019
Pigment print on cotton rag
42 x 28 in / 107 x 72 cm

YASMINE DIAZ

A Yemeni–American, Yasmine Diaz has lived most her life in the United States, a country that bears undeniable responsibility in the escalating crisis in Yemen and throughout the Middle East. Sourcing content from top U.S. news outlets, The Wall Street Journal, The New York Times, USA Today, and the Los Angeles Times, Diaz focuses on the disproportionate distribution of information about one the most dire issues of our time. In these works, Diaz examines the censored and limited U.S. media coverage of the conflict in Yemen. Salon, an online U.S. media site, recently reported that MSNBC, a major U.S. news network, did not mention the war in Yemen a single time during the same one year period that it aired 455 segments on Stormy Daniels, an alleged mistress of U.S. President Donald Trump. This absurd discrepancy comes as no surprise in the current age of clickbait–driven media cycles, where news of another war in the Middle East is not as appealing to American viewers as the countless brazen affairs of the current President. Perhaps most influential is the problematic relationship between the U.S. and Saudi Arabia, whose direct support of Yemeni government forces have resulted in a blockade preventing aid and commercial goods from reaching civilians as well the destruction of infrastructure worsening the humanitarian catastrophe.

August 10, 2018 references the day after a Saudi–led coalition airstrikes hit a bus driving in a busy market in northern Yemen, killing at least 50 people including numerous children. Had this type of catastrophe taken place in a number of other countries, it would have been headline news, but U.S. media outlets were virtually silent the following day.

With Fool's Gold, Diaz considers U.S. news coverage of the war in Yemen over a six month period. Collaged articles mimic a graph reflecting a spike in attention during the month of October, 2018, when news of Jamal Khashoggi's disappearance began to break. As the situation escalated, U.S. media began to heavily scrutinize its government's relationship with Saudi Arabia and the role the United States was playing in the 3 1/2 year old war in Yemen. Conversely, as news of Khashoggi receded so did media attention to the war. On October 17, Pompeo traveled to meet with Mohammed bin Salman to discuss Khashoggi's disappearance. That same day $100 million was transferred from Saudi Arabia to the US (for reported U.S. stabilization efforts in Syria).

Fragments of news articles on the war and Khashoggi's disappearance are over–layed with multiple gold–hued mediums: glitter, powdered metallic pigment, and gold leaf composite. These inexpensive representations of gold are much like fool's gold, whose value does not begin to compare to its simulacrum. With this work, Diaz questions the exchange of value between the United States and Saudi Arabia. U.S. officials have touted its allyship and arms contracts with the oil–rich Middle Eastern country as a tremendous benefit to the economy and global security. But at what cost, moral or otherwise? This relationship has undoubtedly affected the awareness of the American people about the conflict in Yemen. Diaz furthermore questions if the rise and fall of scintillating headlines make viewers implicit in the state–sponsored narratives that instill collective amnesia.

Fool's Gold, 2019
Collage, glitter, powdered pigment,
and composite gold leaf on wood panel
18 x 24 in / 45.7 x 61 cm

August 10, 2018, 2018
Mixed media collage and glitter on
watercolor paper
30 x 22 in / 76.2 x 55.88 cm

Averting is Easy, 2018
Mixed media collage and glitter on
watercolor paper
30 x 22 in / 76.2 x 55.88 cm

THANA FAROQ

Thana Faroq's series, *In Search of Lost Photographs*, was born out of the partial loss of the artist's photo archives. The photographs had originally been taken between 2013–2014, during the National Dialogue Conference following Yemen's Uprising in 2011 and subsequent political turmoil. Amidst the shock and devastation of losing over 1000 photos taken in her hometown, Sana'a, she embarked on a project to recreate images that she no longer possessed.

Faroq is unable to return to Sana'a, and even were she able to travel there, she could not recreate scenes prior to the current war; many of the individuals that she had captured on camera have fled the city or are no longer alive. The 18 images that constitute this series possess attributes that simulate the appearance of digitally scanned archival photographs. This is however a fabrication by the artist, who has not found her lost photographs but has instead (re)created them.

The new images are taken from the artist's surviving archives of digital photographs. Upon encountering an image that reminds her of another that was lost, she transforms it into a photograph from her memory by removing the color, and digitally enhancing the graininess, among other alterations. In the process of creating certain works, she began to recall the visuals of other photographs which, in turn, led to all the works in this series. The making of *In Search of Lost Photographs* is an exercise of remembering which ultimately blurs fact and fiction, reality and recollection. It is an echoing archive of Faroq's fragmented memories.

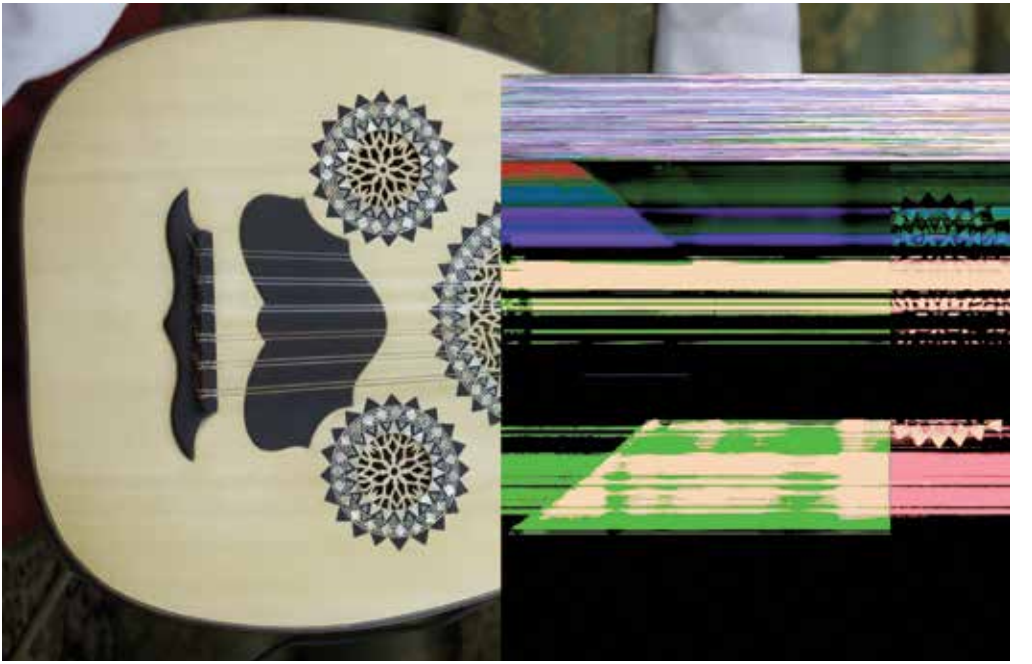
Following page and spread
Untitled (In Search of Lost Photographs), 2018
Video featuring 18 rotating images
2 minutes and 40 seconds

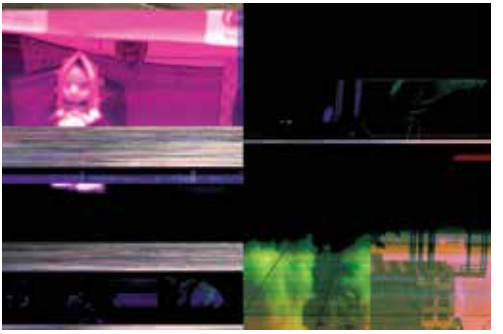
ARIF AL NOMAY

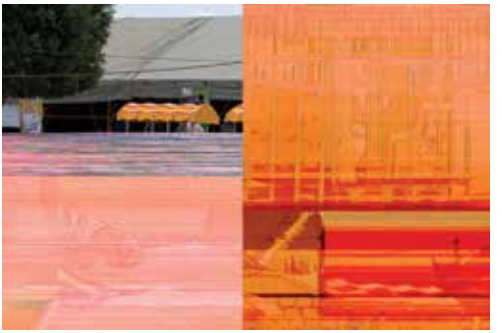
Arif Al Nomay's *Corrupted Files* series is heavily symbolic in its poetic undertones concerning Yemen's recent past and current state. Consisting of a happenstance technical glitch, hundreds of photos taken at the 2014 Sana'a Summer Festival appear corrupted when opened on the artist's computer. At the time the photos were taken, the Yemeni government had undergone two years of transitional negotiations at the National Dialogue Conference, following the Yemeni Arab Spring Uprising and subsequent political unrest. The corrupted images have become compilations of multiple photographs, with some sections and colors left intact, while others are pixelated and indistinguishable. Yet individuals, objects and landscapes are visible despite the visual chaos of this joyous and lighthearted celebration. The works are presented for the first time in a large–scale grid, displaying the disjointed elements in each piece and showcasing the magnitude of the series as a whole.

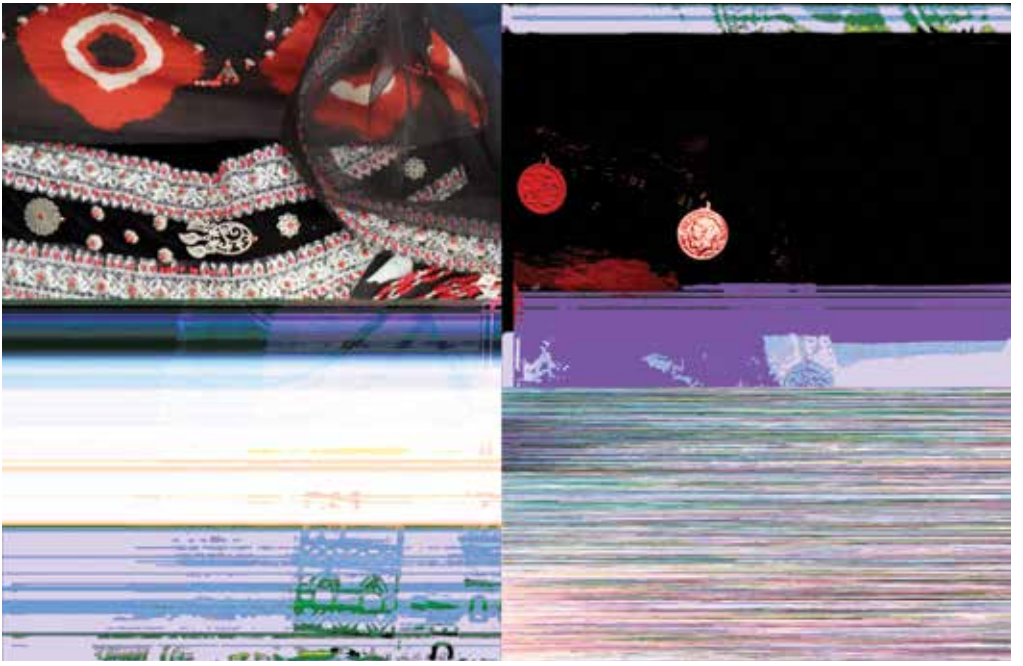
Following page and spread
Corrupted Files Series, 2014–2018
Installation of 84 photographs
7 x 9.5 in / 18 x 24 cm (Each)

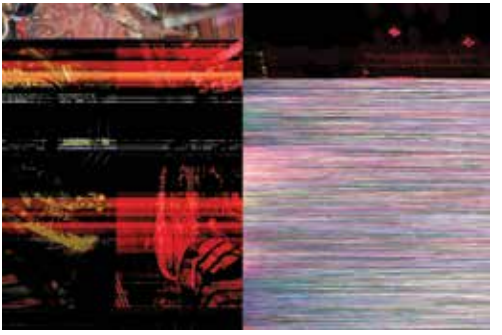
Spread pages 42–43
File 4252 (Corrupted Files Series), 2014–2018
Digital Photograph

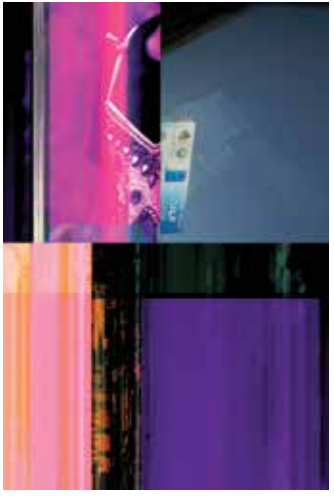


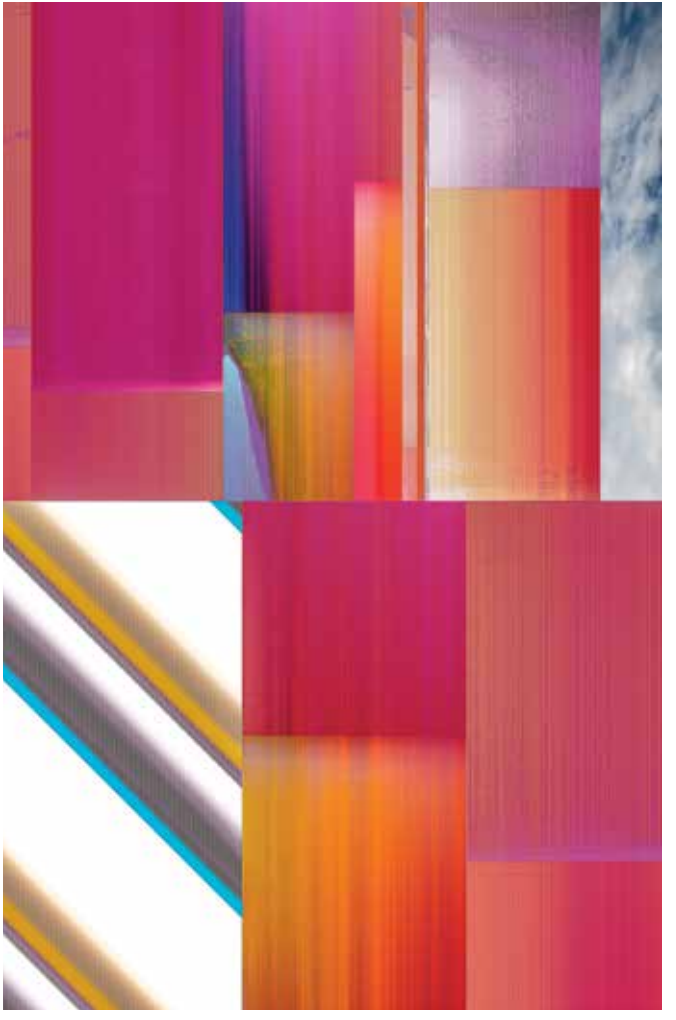












RAHMAN TAHA

In *Ali*, Rahman Taha presents a multi–media installation exploring history and society in Yemen through a day in the life of Ali—an elderly man who has spent the majority of his life working on Yemen's renowned coffee plantations in the mountains of the Northwest. Nearly 80 years old, Ali has lived through Yemen's major conflicts over the past century. Through photographs, filmed discussions, and shadowing of the subject throughout his daily activities, viewers are privy to a substitute history of Yemen: one which evades linear events revolving around the nation. Instead, Ali's perspectives are facetious, mundane and at times, incomprehensible. They touch upon larger concepts of life, the shifting nature of relations between men and women in Yemen that Ali has observed over past decades, in addition to reflections on politics and history.

Another central figure in this work is the landscape of the mountain–range itself, and Ali's relationship to the land which pertains to his profession as a coffee grower. Through inquiries about his work, Ali reveals detailed knowledge about the earth that he has cultivated his whole life, and other technicalities of this industry throughout Yemen's recent history. The landscape, its colors, aroma and the omnipresence of its harvest in sustaining life in that region, is a larger testament to history. It is a reminder that the geology of this land has existed and will continue to exist far longer than any human or man–made conflict.

Following page
Mr. Ali, 2019
C–print
23.6 x 23.6 in / 60 x 60 cm

Following spread
Mr. Ali, 2019
C–print
15.7 x 23.6 in / 40 x 60 cm

IBN SEERA

Yemen is renowned for its striking architecture that was developed over centuries by builders and craftsmen using locally sourced materials and suiting the specific climate and geography of the region. Both the North and South boast unique architectural design traits that highlight the diversity throughout the country. As Yemen suffered consecutive civil strifes, cities all over the country have also borne the wreckage of this destruction. However, for a variety of reasons, efforts to rebuild have often fallen short of maintaining the identity of regional architectural traditions, which has lead to a further loss of cultural heritage.

In the film *(de)Constructing Heritage*, Ibn Seera uses primary and secondary photographic research to record architectural shifts that have taken place in the Yemeni city of Aden following various eras of unrest. The video consists of the artist revealing to the viewer a map of Aden and opening image files from folders on a computer desktop pertaining to specific buildings and other iconic structures throughout the city. Specifically, the study looks at schools, historical landmarks, shuttered windows and places of worship, such as mosques of varying sects and synagogues. As the viewer observes juxtaposed images of the sames structures following their destruction/ reconstruction or throughout various historical eras, the physical change in the architecture and facades or outright erasure of the buildings is evident.

Following page
Primary and secondary research of the Hamed Mosque in Aden, Yemen used for *(de)Contructed Heritage* video work.

محمد حامد
الشاف

السنابل

Primary and secondary research of the Aden Synagogue in Aden, Yemen used for *(de)Contructed Heritage* video work.

Primary and secondary research of the Aban Mosque in Aden, Yemen used for *(de)Contructed Heritage* video work.

ALIA ALI (1985) is a Yemeni–Bosnian–American multi–media artist. Her aesthetic interests stem from people, place, and the processes which unite and divide us, all at once. Her work reflects on the politics and poetics of contested notions surrounding the topics of identity, physical borders, universality, mental/physical spaces of confinement, and the inherent dualism that exists in everything. Her work blurs the lines between what we claim to be objective and subjective, illusion and reality, truth and interpretation.

Alia holds a BA in Middle Eastern Studies and Studio Art from Wellesley College and is currently based in Los Angeles where she is pursuing her MFA at California Institute of the Arts. Her work has most recently been exhibited at the Peter Sillem Gallery, Frankfurt; Gulf Photo Plus, Dubai; Galerie Siniya 28, Marrakech; Lianzhou Photo Festival, Lianzhou; and the Contemporary Art Center, New Orleans.

YASMINE DIAZ (1977) navigates overlapping tensions around religion, gender, and third–culture identity using personal archives, found imagery and various media on paper. Born and raised in Chicago to parents who immigrated from Yafa in the highlands of southern Yemen, her mixed media work often reflects personal histories of the opposing cultures she was raised within.

She has exhibited and performed at spaces including: the Brava Theater, San Francisco; the Albuquerque Museum of Art; and The Main Museum, Los Angeles. Her work is in the collections of the Los Angeles County Museum of Art, The University of California Los Angeles, and The Poetry Project Space in Berlin. Diaz is a 2019 California Community Foundation Visual Artist Fellow. She lives and works in Los Angeles.

IBN SEERA is the pseudonym of an Aden–based Yemeni artist. The artist has chosen to conceal his identity due to the sensitivity of the research and documentation presented in his work.

THANA FAROQ (1989) is a documentary photographer and storyteller currently living in the Netherlands. In 2016, she was awarded the "Break the Silence" scholarship to pursue an M.A. in Documentary Photography and Photojournalism at the University of Westminster, London. Her work aims to achieve a personal reportage that negotiates themes of memory, boundaries, and violence. She focuses on collaborative storytelling projects to tell personal anecdotes of displacement and migration. Previously, Thana worked with various international NGOs in Yemen to tell stories of displacement women and children in Yemen, portraying the suffering and highlighting this forgotten crisis. Her work has appeared in several publications including: Aljazeera, World Press Photo, BBC, Huffington Post, and CNN among others. In 2018, Faroq was awarded the Open Society Foundations fellowship grant and exhibition for her ongoing project The Passport.

ARIF AL NOMAY (1970) was born in Ibb, Yemen and is currently based between Yemen and Saudi Arabia. A self–taught artist, he is also a freelance photographer and documentary filmmaker. His practice explores the narratives, aesthetics, culture, and politics of Yemen. He has exhibited his work throughout Saudi Arabia, most notably at Pharan Studio and Hafez Gallery in Jeddah, the UAE, Germany and France, at the Institut du Monde Arabe in Paris. In 2017, he was the recipient of the annual Photography LIVE contest in Dubai, UAE.

RAHMAN TAHA (1989) is a professional photographer based in Sana'a, Yemen. Previously he coordinated art exhibitions in Raufa Hassan Gallery in Sana'a, one of the best known art galleries in Yemen. He is currently a photojournalist with Al–Madaniya Magazine and is a visual consultant for Mocha Hunters, a leading Yemeni coffee enterprise. His work has appeared in numerous international publications including The New Yorker, and Deutsche Zeitung, Al–Hayat, Nafas Art Magazine, and Forbes. He has exhibited his work in both solo and group exhibitions throughout Yemen, as well as in Madrid, Spain.

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